AMERICAN VOICES

1.4 Benjamin Franklin 1706–1790

"To succeed, jump as quickly at opportunities as you do at conclusions."—Benjamin Franklin

Benjamin Franklin seized just about every opportunity that came his way. When he was 17, he ran away from his home in Boston to seek a fresh start in a new city. He eventually ended up in Philadelphia. There, the multitalented Franklin worked as a printer, an inventor, and a scientist. His experiments on the nature of electricity, conducted with his famous kite, brought him international fame. But it is as a statesman that he is best known—and honored.

A REPRESENTATIVE IN ENGLAND

When the Stamp Act was passed in 1765, Franklin was in England, serving as a colonial representative. He'd been in the country off and on since 1757 and, by all accounts, enjoyed his stay there. Franklin liked to dine in fine restaurants and go to the theater—comforts that the more rustic colonies lacked. He opposed the Stamp Act but didn't think it could be stopped. Franklin had even ordered British stamps to be used in his Philadelphia printing firm.

The colonists' response to the passage of the act took him completely by surprise. Franklin learned that mobs of Americans were joining together to prevent the act's enforcement. He also discovered that his acceptance of the despised Stamp Act



The National Portrait Gallery Washington, D.C.

French artist Joseph Siffred Duplessis painted two very similar portraits of Benjamin Franklin, but only this one hangs in the National Portrait Gallery. For the most part, only the color and style of Franklin's coat differ in the two paintings. In both, as one person noted, the subject's "large forehead suggests strength of mind" and his expression conveys "the smile of an unshakeable serenity."

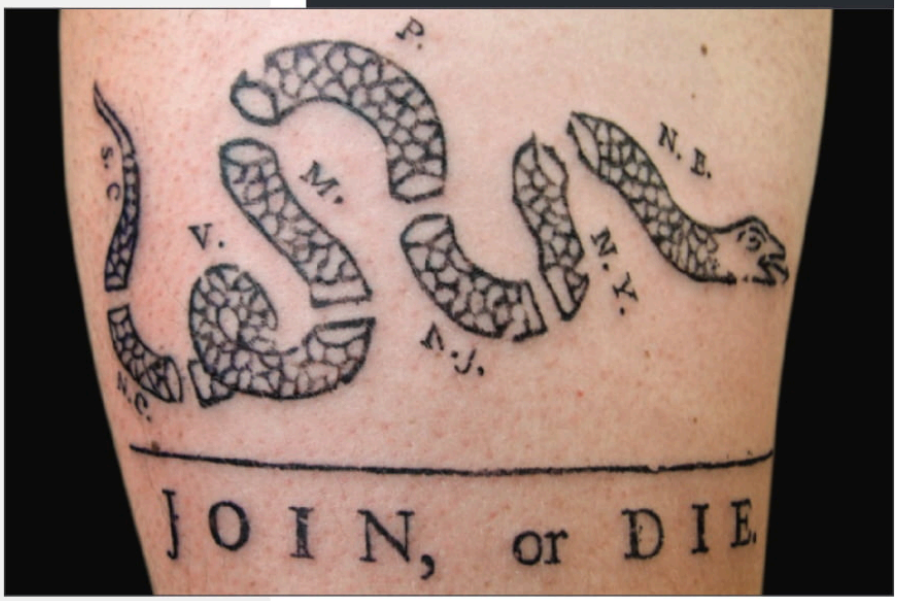
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Our American Identity

You may have seen the "Join, or Die" cartoon before, but did you know that Franklin was the artist? The pieces of the snake are meant to roughly represent the 13 colonies. "N.E." stands for the New England colonies of New Hampshire, Massachusetts, Rhode Island, and Connecticut.

Franklin's cartoon found its most popular meaning later, when the colonists' futures were at risk. For many, the choice to support the colonies in North America involved abandoning their identity as Europeans and, instead, identifying themselves as Americans at a time when no one knew what that might mean. The stakes were high, but the eloquent words of people like Franklin carried the day.

CRITICAL VIEWING Franklin's famous political cartoon is shown today tattooed on someone's calf. Based on what you know about the cartoon and its message, what might you infer about this person, regardless of what you think of tattoos?



had begun to tarnish his reputation. Stirred to action, Franklin spoke eloquently to Parliament, condemning the act and explaining the colonists' position. His speech was instrumental in the act's repeal. The experience made Franklin feel what he called his "Americanness" as never before. He also began to question his loyalty to Britain and its treatment of the colonies.

A SUPPORTER OF INDEPENDENCE

Over the next few years, Franklin tried to smooth over the differences between Britain and the colonies and help each side understand the other. To achieve that goal, he worked closely with Thomas Hutchinson, the governor of Massachusetts. Hutchinson was supposed to defend the rights of the colonists, but he really acted on behalf of King George. Secretly, he was working to limit the colonists' rights. When Franklin uncovered letters that detailed Hutchinson's intentions, he sent them to America. The letters fueled the colonists' anger with British rule.

The letters' release also led the British government to condemn Franklin, who shortly thereafter returned to America. His experiences in England had convinced him that the colonies should break away from Britain. At the outset of the French and Indian War in 1754, Franklin had created a political cartoon called "Join, or Die" to urge the colonies to unite and fight with Great Britain against the French. Now the cartoon came to symbolize colonial unity against the British.

As colonial protests mounted against Britain and the king, Franklin became a strong voice for independence and democracy. He would help draft the Declaration of Independence and was among the first to sign it, saying as he did so, "We must indeed all hang together, or most assuredly we shall all hang separately."

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What official role did Franklin have while he lived in England?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What realization led to Franklin's dissatisfaction with British rule?
3. **MAKE INFERENCES** Franklin said he was feeling his "Americanness" as never before. How might Franklin have described the American identity at that time in history?

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